We had Dr Roy and Vinod Dua—a unique and stellar English–Hindi combination—holding forth in the studio. Private news television networks had still not taken off, so we had a virtual monopoly over viewership. The nation was, literally, watching us. It was also a pre-electronic voting machine era—the results would come through very slowly and the entire exercise went on for three days, like a slowly unfolding Hindi film drama. In fact, to keep the audiences engaged, Doordarshan would break the election coverage with old movies.

I was reporting out of the Congress headquarters for those seventy-two hours; among my colleagues in the field were Arnab and Barkha. One episode sticks in my mind of that time. On day three of the coverage I got a call from Kamal Nath, the senior Congress leader. Nath had been denied a Congress ticket after his name surfaced in the Jain hawala scam. He was convinced that the hawala charges had been a conspiracy by then prime minister Narasimha Rao to edge out all his political rivals. As the results were coming in, it was apparent that Rao was on his way out. Nath wanted his revenge.

Around 8 in the evening, he called me and said he wanted to do a live interview with me from the Congress headquarters. I warned him that the party viewed him as a persona non grata, and might not allow him to enter the premises. ‘Don’t worry, Narasimha Rao is history, my friend. Today I will expose him before the nation,’ he told me. Sounds like a scoop, I thought, and invited him to join the telecast.

An hour later, a slightly inebriated Nath arrived at the venue. We did a live interview where he, as promised, lambasted the Rao government. There was only one hitch—this was Doordarshan and Rao was still technically prime minister of India. A few minutes into the interview, I was getting frantic signals to cut the live telecast. Nath, though, was on a roll. ‘History has taught Rao a well-deserved lesson. Thank God the country is rid of him!’ It is perhaps the one and only occasion when the prime minister has been spoken about in this manner on Doordarshan!

That was, of course, eighteen years ago. Now, we were into another general election in the age of private television where dozens of news